

Face-2-Face with Employer

“You really have to redefine the technology of how the world communicates. It’s not just about communication at the handset level. It could be two networks or even two continents talking to each other.”

Indu Kapoor
HR business partner
Research and Development
Alcatel Lucent, NCR Region

Power of the tower!

Can you imagine yourself without a mobile phone? No, because telecom has become a lifeline for the world at large. The lifeline is supported by a tower, the base station, that stands tall in your city and ensures your connectivity at all times.

As more people buy cell phones for the first time, mobile service providers have to install more antennae and base service stations. In turn, the demand for those who specialise in telecom design and implementation is bound to rise.

Recently in India, many new telecom companies were awarded licenses to operate in various states across India. Some of them hold a Pan India License. The entry of so many players in telecom throws up many issues. How are these new players going to establish themselves? From where will they get people to operate? How will they scale at the pace they want?

Amongst the world economies, India has one of the fastest growing telecom networks with its high population and development potential. While over 380 million people own mobile phones in the country today, the number will shoot up to 500 million mobile users by 2010, as telecom operators will look to tap the unexploited rural market (source: Mobile Marketing Association (MMA)). This creates a huge need for professionals with relevant telecom backgrounds to support, service and meet the demands of the sector.

What drove your choice of this career?

Veer Chand Bothra, Revenice: I got hooked to the internet early on (mid-90s). Soon I was keen to work on technologies which drove the internet. I have mostly been on the software development side in telecom equipment manufacturers (TEM) though I have also worked on network planning/deployment.

What are the required skills set?

Veer Chand Bothra: To be a part of this industry, and survive, one has to have an inherent desire to learn (and learn endlessly), because whatever technology you may be working on today will be old tomorrow. Hard work is another pre-requisite. If you have the tendency to put off work, take your own time in learning, this is not the place for you. Also, you have to have customer-oriented thinking. A bachelor's degree in engineering is required for most fields listed above.

Required mind set

Veer Chand Bothra: The mind set required is very open to learn and change. Maybe a new technology a day! You have to keep your mind adaptable to the ever changing pace of the industry.

One could always move to network deployments or in defining the standards. This takes a lot of effort to master a field completely. Also, one can move from a TEM to an operator to an integrator.

There are tremendous prospects both at the entry and at the middle levels. The emerging hot areas in this profession are: convergence – IMS, IP on the backhaul, etc; wireless 3G/4G/LTE, web applications that solve communication-related problems.

“The student should be strong in Physics and Mathematics. Ideally, good mathematical analysis, programming, signal processing, concepts of telecom should be focused on. Communication today drives society. A student gets a decent idea on how these work. Also one must understand how communication works over the cell phone, internet and TV. We receive as low as 10 to